

Alessandro Guidi

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Prof. Dr. Tereza Tykvová

Chair of Private Markets and Alternative Investments

Swiss Institute of Banking and Finance (s/bf-HSG), University of St. Gallen

Re: Research Associate / Ph.D. Student in Private Markets (Ref. 2023-1092)

Dear Professor Tykvová,

I am writing to apply for the Research Associate / Ph.D. Student position in Private Markets at the Swiss Institute of Banking and Finance. I am an ML researcher with a background in private-market valuation, an accepted publication in the area, and a clear wish to pursue an academic-oriented PhD under your supervision — the position describes almost exactly the path I want to build.

My interest in private markets is concrete rather than abstract. My paper *Can Non-Financial Signals Price Private Companies?* (accepted, WI2026 Student Track; with S. Rashid and H. Zhong, ESCP) studies 3,403 PitchBook venture deals under a strict out-of-time holdout across the post-2022 correction. Two findings connect directly to your research programme. First, the dominant driver of pricing is not firm financials but **investor-syndicate capacity** (the collective AUM of the lead investors accounts for ~31% of model importance) — an empirical confirmation of the certification effect, and a result that speaks to your work on syndication and selection in venture and private equity. Second, adding financial and macro data to a purely non-financial model yields negligible improvement ("information saturation"), which raises a question I find genuinely open: *which information is actually worth acquiring before a private-market decision, and at what cost?*

That question is what I would like to develop into a doctoral research line: bringing the economics of the *value of information* into private-market investment decisions, with the empirical rigour your Chair is known for. Crucially, the work does not depend on proprietary data — a point-in-time reconstruction of public sources (excluding look-ahead, in the spirit of the out-of-time design I already use) combined with a virtual-fund simulator provides a testable ground truth. I would value the empirical private-markets environment of your Chair as the home for this, and I am open to shaping the topic within your group's ongoing research agenda.

On background: I hold a Master in Management from ESCP Business School (GPA 3.8/4.0; Corporate Finance / Financial Markets) and a B.Sc. from the University of Turin (110/110). I work in Python (scikit-learn, XGBoost, SHAP) with strong empirical-analysis skills — tree ensembles, regularised regression, temporal validation, and interpretability — and I have professional experience at Amazon and Capgemini that keeps my work close to practice. I read and write English fluently.

I attach my CV and my WI2026 paper as an example of my academic writing, and my transcripts are included with this application. Thank you very much for considering my application — I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my work could contribute to your group.

Kind regards,
Alessandro Guidi

References

Prof. Hao Zhong — Associate Professor of Business Analytics; Scientific Co-Director, MSc in Business Analytics & AI, ESCP Business School (Paris). hzhong@escp.eu

Soukaina Hafidi — Senior Key Account Manager, Amazon. shafidi@amazon.fr